

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Spate of traffic fatalities a concern

Citywide, they're occurring at higher rate than before pandemic

By Sam Charles
Chicago Tribune

The officers were just north of 71st Street when they saw a man lying in the middle of Western Avenue, close to the eastern boundary of the Chicago Police Department's 8th District.

It was about 10:30 p.m. May 13, and several witnesses told police that a silver vehicle was speeding north on the busy thoroughfare when the driver struck the man crossing the street.

An ambulance took the injured 76-year-old to Advocate Christ Medical Center in Oak Lawn, but he was soon pronounced dead.

Police records indicate he was just half a mile from his home. The offending driver, witnesses said, kept going north on Western after the collision.

The man was among the hundreds killed in recent years in car crashes in Chicago. Citywide, fatal crashes now are occurring at a higher rate than before the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020, when stay-at-home orders forced scores of drivers to keep off the roads.

Since the start of 2019, more than 1,040 people have died of injuries suffered in Chicago motor vehicle crashes, according to data from the Cook County medical examiner's

office. Of those, more than 300 were pedestrians. About 200 of those died in crashes that occurred on Chicago expressways, records show.

Of the dead, more than 30 were children aged 14 or younger.

In 2019, the year before the pandemic, Chicago recorded 115 traffic fatalities, according to medical examiner's office data. Five years later, in 2024, the city saw 175 traffic-related deaths — a 52% increase. Through the first four months of 2025, another 32 people were killed in Chicago crashes, data show.

Turn to Crashes, Page 4



Fernando Ochoa displays a photo of his mother, Maria Ochoa Flores, on Tuesday, days after she was struck and killed while walking by a car involved in a collision in Chicago. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



Rows of trees on the southern edge of the former Arlington International Racecourse are lit by the sunrise Friday in Arlington Heights. For the Bears to build a new stadium on the site, the team will need buy-in from many groups. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

A LONG WAY TO GO

The Bears' proposed move to Arlington Heights would require complicated approval by local taxing bodies

By Robert McCoppin
Chicago Tribune

The Chicago Bears have submitted required traffic and financial impact studies to Arlington Heights, marking the next step in their quest to build a new football stadium there.

The studies are considered preliminary drafts that will be worked on further with a village consultant, so Village Manager Randall Recklaus declined to release them publicly for now.

But a Bears move to Arling-

ton Heights will require much more than those plans. It will also require an extensive review by local school districts, a park district, and even, potentially, the Northwest Mosquito Abatement District.

That's because the team agreed to a complicated process that empowers a joint review board of all taxing bodies on the former Arlington International Racecourse to approve or reject any tax deal. Which means if the Bears want a new dome, they'll need buy-in from those groups.

"There'll be a process that's going to begin, and there'll be an enormous amount of opportunity for every resident and every business owner to become educated and participate in all the dialogue that's going to happen," new Mayor Jim Tinaglia said at the most recent Village Board meeting. "And this entire board, believe me, will all have something to say, and it will be wonderful, or it won't be."

Significantly, the joint review board vote on the stadium is weighted by each agency's share

of the tax bill. That means three school districts can decide the issue, since they collect a majority of the tax burden.

As the team found out previously, getting agreement from the school districts can be difficult. At one point, the team reached an impasse with the schools, and turned its attention instead to building a stadium in Chicago.

But when state leaders rejected the notion of public funding to help pay for the Chicago site, Bears officials recently said they are shifting their focus back to the suburban site, which they own and where they can develop an entertainment district of hotels,

Turn to Move, Page 2

US trims COVID vaccine guidelines

Recommendation ends for most kids and pregnant women

By Apoorva Mandavilli
and Christina Jewett
The New York Times

The COVID-19 vaccine will no longer be recommended for healthy children or healthy pregnant women, Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. announced Tuesday.

The vaccines had been recommended by the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention since they first became available for those groups several years ago.

"I couldn't be more pleased to announce that as of today, the COVID vaccine for healthy children and healthy pregnant women has been removed from the CDC recommended immunization schedule," Kennedy said in a video he posted on the social platform X.

Before joining the Trump administration, Kennedy had long campaigned against vaccinating children to protect them from COVID-19 — even threatening to sue the FDA if it authorized such shots for children. In making the announcement, Kennedy seems to have reneged on a promise he made to Sen. Bill Cassidy, R-La., not to alter the childhood immunization schedule.

Flanked by Dr. Marty Makary and Dr. Jay Bhattacharya, who lead the Food and Drug Administration and the National Institutes of Health respectively, Kennedy said in the video that there was no clinical data to support additional shots for healthy children.

However, pediatricians point out that the youngest infants face among the highest risks for hospitalization, similar to older adults.

Kennedy's decision upends the standard process for such recommendations, which are made by advisers to the CDC and accepted — or overruled — by the agency's director. The health secre-

Turn to Vaccine, Page 6

INSIDE

Get ready for patio season in Chicago

Bars and restaurants are preparing for the weather to warm up and already have opened patios for the season. Dive into the ones worth exploring. **Food & Health**

New Blackhawks coach is on the clock

Jeff Blashill has been handed the reins to the next stage of the team's rebuild but says he won't "rush the process." **Chicago Sports**



Mayor Brandon Johnson speaks to members of the media during a news conference at City Hall on Tuesday. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Johnson urges 'expediency' to address CTA fiscal cliff

Illinois lawmakers consider proposals as end of session nears

By Alice Yin
and Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson on Tuesday reiterated his urgency for Springfield to hammer out a deal addressing the Chicago Transit Authority's fiscal cliff before the legislative session ends this week, while remaining vague

on his latest demands.

At his weekly City Hall news conference, the mayor again called for Chicago-area transit to receive an "equitable distribution and fair share of resources" as state lawmakers mull proposals including whether to tie a bailout of the CTA to a proposal overhauling the governance structure of the Chicago area's public transit systems. However, it remained unclear what the Johnson administration's role

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TODAY'S WEATHER



High 59 Low 52

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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